

Fine Print

Product Requirements Document

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Summary

I built Fine Print to close a gap I kept running into: the people most exposed by a contract are the ones least equipped to read it. Enterprise contract-review tools exist, but they are priced and designed for legal teams. The person signing their first lease, accepting a freelance gig, or clicking through terms of service has nothing. Fine Print is a consumer triage tool that reads a contract clause by clause, scores each clause for risk, explains it in plain language, and, most importantly, flags the standard protections that are missing.

Problem

Contracts are written for lawyers, not for the people bound by them. The asymmetry is well documented: 91% of people accept terms without reading them, and in one nonprofit review, 40% of leases examined contained questionable clauses. At \$349 an hour, a lawyer is not a realistic option for a routine lease or freelance agreement. I decided the highest-leverage thing I could build was not another clause-by-clause reader, but a tool that also tells someone what should be in their contract and isn't, because absent protections are the risks people least expect and most regret.

Who it's for

- **The first-time renter** signing a lease they don't fully understand, under time pressure.
- **The side-hustle freelancer** handed a one-sided client agreement with no leverage to hire counsel.
- **The terms acceptor** who clicks through ToS and wants to know, after the fact, what they agreed to.

Goals and non-goals

Goals.

- Make any supported contract understandable to a non-lawyer in under a minute.
- Surface both risky clauses and missing protections.
- Be honest about uncertainty rather than projecting false confidence.

Non-goals.

- I am not building a legal-advice product or a lawyer substitute. The FTC's action against DoNotPay drew that line clearly, and I designed to stay on the correct side of it.
- I am not targeting enterprise legal teams; the existing tools serve them well.
- I am not attempting jurisdiction-specific legal analysis.

Key decisions

I made a handful of decisions that defined the product. Each had a real tradeoff.

One foundation-model call, not a trained pipeline

I chose a single well-prompted foundation-model call over a custom multi-stage NER pipeline. A trained pipeline would need thousands of labeled contracts and months of work; for a consumer tool providing legal information, a foundation model reaches usable accuracy with no training data. I accept the tradeoff that accuracy is unmeasured, and I disclose it rather than hide it.

Read and analyze uploads in one call

For PDFs and photos, I have the model read the document and return structured analysis in a single call rather than extracting text first and analyzing second. This roughly halved response time. The cost is that I cannot verify quotes against a source text for uploads, which I flag in the interface.

Deterministic scoring, client-side

I compute the 0 to 100 health score with a fixed formula on the client, never with the model. I did this because a trust tool cannot show a score that drifts run to run or contradicts the clauses on screen. The same clauses always produce the same score.

Self-consistency as an opt-in, not a default

I added a deep-check mode that runs the analysis twice and flags clauses the two runs disagree on. I deliberately made it opt-in rather than default: it doubles cost and latency, and forcing that on a simple one-page lease would be the wrong tradeoff. Letting the user spend the extra time and cost where the stakes justify it is the better product decision, and a more honest one.

I also chose to stop there rather than add a third adversarial pass. More verification is not automatically better; a third pass added cost and introduced new false positives that would erode trust faster than it caught misses. Knowing where to stop was part of the design.

Features

- **Three input paths** — paste text, upload a PDF, or photograph multiple pages and analyze them as one document.
- **Clause analysis** — every clause extracted, categorized, risk-scored, and explained in plain language.
- **Gap detection** — missing standard protections flagged as critical or recommended.
- **Health score and verdict** — a single number and a one-line read on the contract overall.
- **Reliability signals** — unverified quotes, uncertain clauses, partial coverage, and confidence levels all shown to the user.

Screens

- **Input** — choose a path; for photos, capture and review pages before analyzing.
- **Processing** — honest progress and time estimate, longer when deep check is on.
- **Overview** — health ring, clause breakdown, reliability banners, detected type and confidence.
- **Clauses** — every clause, risk-first, expandable, with original text and explanation.
- **Gaps** — missing protections and what to do about them.

Reliability requirements

I treated reliability as a first-class requirement, not a polish step, because the product asks people to rely on it. The full rationale lives in the Reliability and Limitations document; in brief, the system must verify quotes against the source, detect and disclose truncated coverage, validate input and refuse non-contracts, offer self-consistency checking, score deterministically, retry transient failures, and signal confidence throughout.

Success metrics

- A non-lawyer can identify the riskiest clause in their contract within one minute of analysis.
- Gap detection surfaces at least one missing protection on the majority of real-world contracts tested.
- Quote verification catches fabricated quotes before they reach the user on pasted-text analyses.
- Deep check disagreement rate stays low enough to be a meaningful signal, not noise.

Ethical constraints

Every screen states that Fine Print provides legal information, not legal advice. This is a hard constraint I set at the start, grounded in the FTC DoNotPay precedent, and it governed positioning, copy, and the decision to surface uncertainty everywhere rather than project authority I cannot back

with a validated accuracy rate.

Limitations and future work

- No jurisdiction awareness yet; adding it is the most valuable next step.
- Accuracy is unmeasured; a lawyer-reviewed benchmark dataset would let me quantify and improve it.
- Five contract types today; the architecture extends to more.
- Quote verification does not yet cover uploads; OCR-then-verify is a possible path.